

3 Writing about compositions

As preparation for submitting a CD sleeve note, students should be given opportunities to write about how pieces studied from the anthology and/or elsewhere influence their own compositions

Students should also practise describing their compositions in terms of form and structure and the balance of repetition and contrast. They should explore how various musical features such as rhythm, melodic development, texture, forces and harmony are treated in their composition.

Students should be aware of the assessment criteria against which the CD sleeve note will be marked.

2.3 Assessment information

1 Assessment overview

In September of each year Edexcel will publish on our website the *Unit 2: Composing* document.

Section A contains four composition briefs from which candidates will select one as the basis for a 3-minute composition.

The topics remain constant during the life of the specification, but the briefs based on them change each year.

Topics for Area of study 1: Instrumental music: *either* Composing expressively *or* Variation structures — composing idiomatically for instruments.

Topics for Area of study 2: Vocal music: *either* words and music — structure in vocal music *or* text, context and texture.

In **Section B**, candidates write a CD sleeve note. They answer three questions which prompt them to describe aspects of their piece and explain how other pieces of music have influenced it.

Both the composition and CD sleeve note must be completed under controlled conditions: 15 hours for the composition and 1 hour for the CD sleeve note. Candidates may have access to the anthology.

The composition and CD sleeve note are externally assessed.

2 The composition

The composition briefs based on the above topics will make compositional demands in terms of the treatment of ideas, techniques and structures but between them will be sufficiently open-ended to allow students the freedom to work in any style or genre. Thus work may use forms and styles associated with western tonal harmony, other techniques of 20th and 21st century art music, popular music and jazz, world music, the media and the stage, and the various modern applications of technology.

The piece may be for any instrument or voice, or combination of instruments and/or voices, and in any style, subject to the requirements of the selected composition brief.

The composition will be marked out of 40 against the assessment criteria in *Section 2.5*.

3 CD sleeve note

CD sleeve notes are written under controlled conditions. However, students are allowed — indeed expected, to research and plan their sleeve notes before the controlled conditions begin. They may take their research into the controlled conditions to help them when writing their sleeve note. The final sleeve note, written under controlled conditions, must address the following three questions.

Question 1

Explain and comment on form and structure, indicating in particular how repetition and contrast are balanced. (4 marks)

Question 2

Mention **four** other features of interest. You can refer to any two or more of the following; rhythm, melodic development, texture, handling of instrument(s) and/or voice(s), harmony. (4 marks)

Question 3

Refer to pieces from the anthology and/or elsewhere, to explain how other pieces of music have influenced you in your composition. (12 marks)

The CD sleeve note will be marked out of 20 against the assessment criteria in *Section 2.6*.

4 Controlled conditions

Students have a maximum of **15 hours** to complete their composition. The 15 hours may be divided into any number of sessions but each session must be supervised. Students have a maximum of **one hour** to complete their CD sleeve note. It is envisaged that this will be a single session.

Supervision must take place within the examination centre and students must work on their composition/technical study only in and during these hours. At other times students' work must be kept under secure conditions in the centre.

Students must not take their composition/technical study home or anywhere else outside the room(s) in which the controlled conditions apply.

Students' access to any instruments or computers must be monitored by the supervisor. Students must not download material from the internet, or email their compositions home or anywhere else outside the room(s) in which the controlled conditions apply. Backup copies of the work for Unit 2 must not be taken out of the room(s) in which the controlled conditions apply.

All students should be advised by their teacher that students' work must be their own, and that they will not sign the declaration form if the work appears not to be original. All students will also be required to sign the declaration form stating that the work is their own.

Note: Students may have access to the anthology whilst completing their composition/technical study.

Note: Recordings of compositions for submission can take place outside the 15 hours. Students may find that they discover areas of their composition that need refining as a result of the performance/recording process. However, no further refining of compositions can take place as a result of the performance/recording after the 15 hours have elapsed.

More guidance on the management of controlled conditions is provided in the 'Getting Started' guide book.